

We must look at the roots of this model of development, understanding its origin, that does not simply mean to understand our past, but examining where the plants draw their nourishment.

Let's start from the phenomenological point of view. How does the contemporary capitalism present itself? It resembles more religious phenomena, more than pragmatical one.

Looking at history of civilization, there's always been a relationships between economy and religion. They sometimes converged, and sometimes clashed.

We'll try to examine some of these dimensions, between what we know as the spirits of northern europe, and the capitalism of southern europe, linked to catholicism.

Spirits cannot be seen though from a phenomenological point of view, so we must look at their traces found in the hermeneutical layers contained within words.

One of the operating mechanism of capitalism is to take these great words, and amputate them. Cutting out their most intimate dimension, creating prototypes.

What is the original point? We start from the thesis that homo economicus, that view on the world and human relationships typical of economics, so to take and cease physically and rename it (zunehemn).

This disposition is much older than economic science itself, as it's more rooted. In fact, long before economics, religion invented homo economicus, particularly through the sacrificial logic. The idea of sacrifice, underlying many religious experience, is nothing more than a currency, a form of exchange that humans applied to their relationship with the divine.

The first merchant was the primitive man, and the first creditor was God.

There exists an archeology of concepts referring from economy and theology.

Theology is also found within economic concepts, with terms like "prize", "credit", "belief", "faith". All these reveal fluidity and reciprocal influence.

Why is the dialogue between economics and theology still so pure? As economists lack economical culture, and so the viceversa is true.

Let's start from 3 points that Benjamin (?) identified as the three main points of capitalism. The first one is that capitalism is a religion of pure cult, with nothing having meaning in relation to the cult, it's pure dogma. The second character is the permanent duration of the cult. This type of religion allows no interaction or pause, with no week days neither holidays. The third point: guilt debt generating. It's the first case of a cult that does not atone for sins, but creates guilt and debt. The idea of a guilty conscience, if it can be redeemed, then it must be universalized.

Is capitalism today still a religion? If so, from what perspective?

Let's consider the ideology of business: it is becoming the primary religion of the age of globalization. This religion is produced in major business schools, which are the new temples of the new sacred. They report enormous success, also because they present their ideology as a technique, which is neutral, claiming universal scope, presented as secular and without dogma. This is however a deception, and what is presented relies on an ideology, and as such it must be examined and criticized.

This new ideology presents its tool as universal, applicable in the same way in Boston, Rome, etc., working the same everywhere. In reality though, behind this technical form, lies a world view. An idea of an individual and social relationships more similar with two main dogmas: meritocracy and incentives. We must pay attention to the managerial ideology of our age. Very little is said about managerial ethics, structuring most of the humans organizations, including justice. How has this ideology managed to reach such a level of diffusion and verbasitness? By being capable to recycle first many of its opponents into collaborators. Contemporary capitalism consume and devours its enemies, conquering them and recruiting them.

Let's think about the criticism we've developed for the net. All that claim that capitalism stereotypes all the concepts of beauty, then were recruited to work in marketing.

Capitalism not only consumes enemies, but also those that are considered to be its prophets, like managers and CEOs.

We can observe that within the wall of these perfect enterprises, some cracks are beginning to appear that we should take seriously. One concerns the emotional fragility of companies. Many corporations now include burnout as a normal stage in development of managerial career, which is becoming inevitable.

Thus, after the first burnout other follows, and after recovery we return to the same toxic dynamics.

At the root of this, the sickness lies a real paradox. A golden rule of the 21th century managerial culture is the absolute prohibition against mixing languages of private life with corporate life. Words like gift, gratitude, friendship that we recognize as important must be kept strictly out of the workplace, as they're consider inappropriate and dangerous.

While this new companies theorize a culture of separation of languages, when they need to select and motivate workers, they instead use words typical of family. Companies speaks of marrying, respect, loyalty, community.

This, as we've learned, as words and codes that activate in individuals the same

dynamics learned and practiced in the private.

The same level of commitment requirements activated in the private sphere, are mimicked in the corporate relationships, but without gratuitness. In traditional companies, in early stages of capitalism, workers and managers were asked for a lot, but not for everything. Other spheres remained, like family, community, religions, etc, which were equally important parts of life.

Capitalism then lies in the loose of symbolic registers, similar to those used in the past by religions, but diminished. New capitalism, especially the digital one, has realised that it needs the people's souls, dedication, vocation ("beruf"). Company needs souls of their workers to obtain the best out of them.

New companies don't need just what is written in the contract. If they fail to activate deepest human motivation, they'll not obtain anything. Companies ask for everything for new hires, like time, priorities, passion, emotions, giving up the boundaries between family and work. Crossing this boundary cannot be justified through the language of money. Only the religious registry of sacrifice can explain what is being asked to young people. If the companies truly recognize the full extent of the work required to workers, they'll create a bound they don't wish to, as the relations would become less manageable.

Recognition is thus limited to the dimension of self giving, and the gift is brought back in the contract. This is the ? theme of stolen gift, as they don't recognize the gift of the workers as such (???)

In early years, this game of promises between company and workers function well. What is called the narcissistic contract fulfill this situation. The company in the young worker see their ideal self, and viceversa. Overtime, this emotional investment accumulates, becoming emotional credit, until one day it becomes clear they'll never be repaid. The gratification turns into ?? (of the early period).

The narcissistic contracts breaks, ...

At some point, the worker realize the game was not worth it, and their life has been consumed in work. For the company, the situation is different. The game continues with new young people, soon replaced by others.

The consumption of youth by large corporations is striking like in army and pagan cults.

Let's look at one of the foundations of neo-managerial ideology: meritocracy.

As we're discussing today, it's the ethical legitimization of inequality. Inequality is a natural condition of human beings, that depends on the throwness. The talents each person receive upon entering in the world differ from one another. The primary inequality is not wealth but talent.

The 20th century attempted to fight this natural condition, dismantling inequality,

trying to change this natural asset.

Periods of equality have always been brief and limited to small communities, while the broader history of Europe has continued to be an history of inequality and ?

The movement of history has created a few islands of equality and fraternity within oceans of inequality. The 20th century tried to reject inequality as inchangeable part, in an attempt to see a world that is not purely natural, but artificial, and beyond biological, not just relying on what is given.

This laboratory was Europe, not USA. Europe fought against natural inequality, creating the welfare state. It enabled women to work and study, children to study instead of workign, and elderly people to retire and live with dignity.

Europe choose to invest in public education for all, and universal healthcare.

While almost everyone was enjoying the benefits of this period, a conter revolution against equality was beginning behind the scenes of economy, finance and politics.

This revolutions was planned and driven primarily by large corporations, with business schools.

For this capitalism to be established as universal cult, and obtain consensus, since no ideology can become universal without consent, it carried a transformation.

The natural inequality became a moral value, known as meritocracy. Inequality changed into a virtue to pursue, as meritocracy present itself as a form of justice.

Natural inequalities are no longer opposed, but praised.

What exactly does this meritocracy need? It's a need, but presenting itself as technique it's not in the religious nature (??)

Meritocracy is the aristocracy of our time, where compared with the medioeval one, only mechanisms of elite reproduction have changed, so no longer blood but merit.

The ideas associated with the word of merit are diverse and different. They vary in object, degree, not only between different people, but also between classes of the same community. Our capitalism show no awareness of its complexity, using the term as it is referred to something simple and understandable.

A first important operation is that talent is reduced to merit, but even before this, there is another fundamental operation: companies reduce the many different merits of individuals into a small number of merits defined as such by companies and owner. Those who defines what comes as merit are managers and owners.

Once many merits are reduced to a few, these few are rewarded and therefore powered. The problem is that meritocracy levels and flattens the many forms of human merits into chosen ones. Within the people who create them and shape them, there are many qualitative merits, which are complex and difficult to measure, which are neither seen or rewarded, but forgotten.

Values like gentleness, mercy, are forgotten. These kept communities together, not only reunited by interest, but by its gratuitousness. Community comes from "communus", so people gather in communities to cooperate, and share gifts.

Who consider these merits today, considering them as such? In the name of a few specific merits, which are quantifiable and measurable, we're witnessing a mass destruction of other talents, which are more humble and humanistic.

There is not just merit, but also opportunity. How much of what we have is a merit, and how much is a gift? All meritocratic theologians and ?, before being theorists of merit, are theorists of de-merit, of guilt.

Underlying all this, is the idea that poor men are guilty of their own condition. The rich deserve their wealth in the eyes of God, while the poor are expiating their faults.

Our constitution states that capable and deserving individuals, even if lacking ?, have the right to reach the higher levels of education.

This formulation should be reconsidered in larger way: those able to reach highest level of education are not only the highest capable, but also the least capable. (??)